Guide for Developing a Chapter of the Foundation for Religious Diplomacy (FRD)

The purpose of FRD is to build trust between religious critics and rivals. FRD's main program for trust-building has been encouraging groups to convene Heart & Mind Conversations using The Way of Openness without a third-party mediator. (For those groups that are interested in the possibility of FRD staff involvement, that is an option too.) This is the foundation of FRD's work. However, even though individual one-time, one-on-one Heart & Mind Conversations can be life-changing, expanding this experience to communities will have more impact. FRD found that members of religious groups wanted to engage in continuous events using written as well as spoken communications to further their trust-building. So FRD Chapters are designed for members of communities that desire to organize ongoing programs that build stronger intra- and interreligious trust.

Early in its history FRD discovered that interreligious conflicts were often influenced by intra-religious conflicts. Sometimes disunity within a group produced the need for an external adversary to create unity. Other times, disagreements over the question of authority to speak for a religious tradition created an inability to address external difficulties. At minimum, knowledge that one's community is not unified affects the clarity and certainty of one's own convictions, and this in turn, diminishes confidence in having safe, open conversations with outsiders.

In short, intra-religious conversations should often precede interreligious ones to build confidence that one has enough trust of one's community to speak as an authentic "insider" even though one is speaking for oneself. FRD Chapters can help their own community members negotiate this dynamic trust-building process that establishes ad-hoc diplomatic authority for participating in interreligious conversations.

When members of a religious tradition desire to create an FRD Chapter, they agree to abide by The Way of Openness in their Heart & Mind Conversations and any communications or events they have under the FRD flag. They will employ FRD's methods and attitudes, but they will design their own programs and internal governance to fit the context of their communities. They will name an FRD Chapter director, approved by FRD management, who will advise the general FRD leadership and vice versa. FRD will have general programming that will invite voluntary participation of the FRD chapters from time to time. Each chapter will oversee its own budget and fund-raising. FRD will provide 501(c)3 status in the USA for the Chapters to raise tax-deductible donations.

Anyone interested in starting an FRD chapter should contact the Managing Director, John Morehead, who will discuss how best to proceed in each case to attain approval.

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